

BEYOND THE CREST

Episode #0002

"A Dead Man Calling" (working title)

Production Code BTC-S01-0002

Air Date: TUESDAY, JANUARY 6, 2026
Season 1

PRODUCTION DRAFT

Beyond the Crest Writers' Room

CAST

Ages as of Tuesday, January 6, 2026

CHARACTER	AGE	ROLE
DET. JEREMY JACKSON	35	Senior Detective, APD Homicide
ELXA JACKSON	35	Chief of Police, APD
DET. ROSA DELGADO	37	Jeremy's partner, APD Homicide
JASMINE OLSON	55	U.S. Representative for Georgia
VICTOR DONOHUE	79	Chairman, The Donohue Company
JOAN DONOHUE	77	Philanthropist; Chair, The Donohue Foundation
EMMA SMILLEY	13	Elder twin; Marc's secret daughter
VICTORIA SMILLEY	13	Younger twin; Marc's secret daughter
LYRIC SOLACE BAKER	13	Working actress; Marc's goddaughter & ward
ESTHER SMILLEY	33	President & COO, Smilley Corporation; designated heir
MARTIN OLSON	34	President, Donohue Broadcasting Group
NATASHA BULLOCK	54	CEO, The Donohue Company
DR. PETER OLSON	56	Chief of Plastic Surgery
LEONARD "TREY" SMILLEY III	13	Son of Nathaniel (Leonard Jr.); Westbrook classmate
KANE MITCHELL	35	Marc's bodyguard; Blackwater enforcer
JOURNEE HOLLOWAY	32	Investigative reporter, The Peach Ledger
DR. FRANCES LOWE	62	Fulton County Medical Examiner
OFFICER DEVON MARSH	26	APD digital forensics technician
THE MAN IN THE RIVER	–	Unidentified body (T-Bone Gaines)
BEVERLY "BEV" HOLLAND	60	Jasmine's chief of staff since 1997
ROBERT BULLOCK	56	Founder, Bullock & Associates, LLP
MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK	34	Heir Apparent; President & COO; SECRET Boss of Blackwater
AMOND BAKER	33	Marc's best friend; SECRET Underboss, Blackwater
HARMONY DIVINE	33	Aspiring filmmaker; SECRETLY "The Tea Kettle ATL"

Also: chef, housekeeper, florists, Westbrook students, Trey's friends, APD officers, reporters and camera crews, BNN anchor (on TV), board member and assistants (V.O.).

SETS

INT. FULTON COUNTY MEDICAL EXAMINER - AUTOPSY SUITE
INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - KITCHEN
INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - VICTOR'S STUDY
INT. WESTBROOK ACADEMY - MAIN HALLWAY
INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - HOMICIDE SQUAD ROOM
INT. DONOHUE TOWER - NATASHA'S OFFICE
INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - HOME GYM
INT. OLSON ESTATE - FOYER
INT. CONGRESSWOMAN OLSON'S DISTRICT OFFICE
INT. DONOHUE BROADCASTING GROUP - MARTIN'S OFFICE
INT. WESTBROOK ACADEMY - CAFETERIA
INT. HARMONY'S APARTMENT - ADAMSVILLE
EXT. APD HEADQUARTERS - FRONT STEPS
EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - ROSE GARDEN
INT. SMILLEY PLAZA - ESTHER'S OFFICE
INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - DIGITAL FORENSICS LAB
INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY
INT. OLSON ESTATE - PETER'S HOME OFFICE
INT. BULLOCK ESTATE - DINING ROOM
EXT. BULLOCK ESTATE - BACK PORCH
INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - TWINS' WALK-IN CLOSET
INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - LYRIC'S ROOM
INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - HOMICIDE SQUAD ROOM - CONTINUOUS
INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY - CONTINUOUS

26 scenes

TEASER**1. INT. FULTON COUNTY MEDICAL EXAMINER - AUTOPSY SUITE -
DAWN (TUE 1/6/26, 6:30 AM)**

Stainless steel and cold white light. A sheet covers a body on the center table. The hum of refrigeration.

DR. FRANCES LOWE (60s; half-moon glasses, a voice like a librarian who has seen everything) stands at the head of the table with a clipboard. Jeremy, in yesterday's shirt and a fresh tie, stands across from her. Rosa leans against the counter with two coffees and gives one to Jeremy.

ROSA

You slept here.

JEREMY

I slept in the car.

ROSA

In the parking deck? It was nineteen degrees.

JEREMY

I ran the heater.

ROSA

Your wife owns a Tahoe with heated seats and you slept in a Crown Vic.

JEREMY

My wife was at a ball.

DR. LOWE

(not looking up)

If the two of you are finished with your marriage counseling, I have a name.

They turn. Dr. Lowe peels back the top of the sheet. The dead man's face, gray and swollen, eyes closed.

DR. LOWE (CONT'D)

The river took most of his fingertips, but we lifted a partial off the left thumb. AFIS matched it at four-twelve this morning.

(reading)

Terrence Anthony Gaines. Forty-one years old. Last known address, a condo on the Westside. Street name "T-Bone."

ROSA

T-Bone. Of course it's T-Bone. Nobody named Terrence ends up in the river.

JEREMY

Record?

DR. LOWE

One arrest. 2019, unlawful possession of a firearm. Charges dismissed.

JEREMY

Dismissed why?

DR. LOWE

That's your department, Detective. I only do the parts that don't talk back.

Jeremy leans over the body. The bruised throat. The thumb marks.

DR. LOWE (CONT'D)

Hyoid fracture, just as I told you yesterday. Bruising on the ribs consistent with a knee. Whoever did this was right-handed and very strong, and he didn't stop when he should have.

(beat)

This wasn't an accident, and it wasn't quick.

JEREMY
Anything else on him?

DR. LOWE
Nothing on him. Something in him.

She lifts an evidence bag from a tray. Inside: a cheap black flip phone, still beaded with river water, and a torn strip of camel-colored silk lining.

DR. LOWE (CONT'D)
The phone your people found sewn into his coat. Digital forensics dried it overnight. It powered on at five-fifty.

She hands Jeremy a printout. A single page.

DR. LOWE (CONT'D)
There's nothing on it. No photos. No texts. Call log wiped.

(beat)
And one saved contact.

Jeremy looks at the page. Rosa reads it over his shoulder.
A single line. A single name.

ARCHITECT.

ROSA
(low)
Who saves somebody as "Architect"?

JEREMY
(staring at it)
Somebody who's afraid to write down their real name.

CUT TO:

2. INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - KITCHEN - MORNING (7:10 AM)

A French country kitchen, bigger than most houses, spotless and bright. A chef plates eggs. A housekeeper pours juice.

At the island, two thirteen-year-old girls sit in matching Westbrook Academy uniforms: plaid skirts, navy blazers, crests on the pockets.

EMMA SMILLEY (13; neat braids, perfectly pressed, a planner open beside her plate) and her twin VICTORIA SMILLEY (13; the same face, one braid already falling out, blazer inside-out, a sneaker on the counter where it absolutely should not be).

They have the same crooked grin. Somebody else's grin.

VICTORIA

(reading from her phone,
dramatic)

"And an update on this morning's item:
our Tuxedo Park princess stayed home
AGAIN. Fourteen years of birthday
invitations, fourteen no-shows."

EMMA

Put it away, Tori.

VICTORIA

"Some allergies run deep." Emma. Emma.
They're talking about Mom.

EMMA

They're not talking about Mom.

VICTORIA

Who else in Tuxedo Park turns down
every party on the ridge?

EMMA

(beat)

Okay, they're talking about Mom.

Esther sweeps in, dressed for the office in a black sheath dress and heels, phone to her ear, a leather portfolio under her arm. She takes the phone out of Victoria's hand

without breaking stride.

ESTHER

No phones at the table.

VICTORIA

It's the island.

ESTHER

No phones at the island.

VICTORIA

The island isn't a table.

ESTHER

In this house, the island is whatever
I say it is.

She sets the phone face-down, glances at the screen before
it goes dark, sees the words THE TEA KETTLE ATL, and her
jaw tightens for half a second.

EMMA

(carefully)

Mom. Were you watching the Donohue
party last night?

ESTHER

No.

VICTORIA

We heard it through the door.

ESTHER

You heard Nana's television. She falls
asleep to BNN.

VICTORIA

Nana was in Palm Beach.

Esther pours coffee and says nothing. Emma kicks her
sister under the counter.

EMMA

(smoothing it over)

It doesn't matter. We just thought it looked pretty. On the news this morning. All the white roses.

VICTORIA

And Marc-Anthony Bullock. In the blue tux. When he spun Lyric around.

ESTHER

(too sharply)

That's enough.

The girls go quiet. Even the chef pauses.

Esther closes her eyes, just for a second. When she opens them, her voice is gentle again.

ESTHER (CONT'D)

I'm sorry. I didn't sleep well.

(beat)

We're Smilleys. We don't watch the Donohues. We compete with them. There's a difference.

VICTORIA

What's the difference?

ESTHER

One of them is how you win.

She kisses the tops of both their heads, grabs her portfolio, and heads for the door.

ESTHER (CONT'D)

Car's out front in ten. Emma, make sure your sister's blazer is right side out.

VICTORIA

(looking down)

Oh my God. How long has it been like this?

EMMA
Since yesterday.

The door closes behind Esther. Victoria turns to her
sister, eyes shining with mischief.

VICTORIA
She was totally watching it.

EMMA
(beat)
She was totally watching it.

CUT TO:
MAIN TITLE

ACT ONE**3. INT. SUMMIT HOUSE - VICTOR'S STUDY - MORNING (8:00 AM)**

The morning after. Four thousand white roses are being carried out by FLORISTS through the hallway behind the open door. Somewhere in the east garden, a peacock screams.

Victor sits behind his desk in a cardigan, reading The Atlanta Beacon. The front page: HIS GRANDFATHER'S HEIR: BULLOCK NAMED DONOHUE PRESIDENT.

Joan, at the tea cart, pours two cups.

The door BANGS open. Winston hurries in behind it, one step too late.

WINSTON

Sir, the Congresswoman...

JASMINE (O.S.)

The Congresswoman can announce herself, Winston.

Jasmine sweeps in. Navy coat, briefcase, fury. She doesn't take off the coat.

VICTOR

(not looking up from the paper)

Good morning, Jasmine.

JASMINE

Is it?

VICTOR

Winston, would you close the door.

WINSTON

(retreating gratefully)

With pleasure, sir.

He closes it. Jasmine stands in the middle of the study. Joan holds out a teacup. Jasmine doesn't take it.

JASMINE

You didn't call me.

VICTOR

I called no one.

JASMINE

You called Natasha.

VICTOR

Natasha is the CEO. She needed to know before the board did.

JASMINE

And I'm your firstborn. I needed to know before five hundred strangers and a DBC camera crew.

Victor folds the newspaper. Sets it down. Takes off his reading glasses.

VICTOR

Sit down, baby.

JASMINE

I've been sitting down for fifty-five years, Daddy. I'm going to stand.

JOAN

Jasmine.

JASMINE

No, Mama. Not this time.

(to Victor)

You stood on that landing and gave my son's birthright away in front of the whole world. You didn't even have the decency to let him hear it in private.

VICTOR

Your son's birthright was never the President's chair. It was a seat at this table. He still has it.

JASMINE

A seat. Below his cousin.

VICTOR

Next to his cousin.

JASMINE

(sharp laugh)

Don't do that. Don't do the politician thing. I invented the politician thing. I've been doing the politician thing in Washington since 1997.

Victor stands. Slowly. At seventy-nine he still fills a room.

VICTOR

Then let me do the father thing. The company goes to the one who will carry it the farthest. That's the covenant your grandfather made and that's the covenant I keep. Not the eldest. Not the loudest. The best.

JASMINE

And you decided that's Marc.

VICTOR

I decided that twenty-one years ago.

JASMINE

When he was twelve years old.

VICTOR

When your son was thirteen and showed me exactly who he was.

Silence. Jasmine goes very still.

JASMINE

What does that mean?

Joan sets down her teacup. A warning glance at her husband.

JOAN

Victor.

VICTOR

(holding Jasmine's gaze)

It means there are things about your son you don't want to know.

JASMINE

(quiet, dangerous)

Try me.

A long beat. Victor looks at his daughter, and for just a moment, the king looks like a tired old man.

VICTOR

Ask Martin what he does with his hands when nobody's watching.

Jasmine's face doesn't move. But her grip on her briefcase handle turns her knuckles white.

JASMINE

You want to know what I think, Daddy?
I think you picked Natasha's son because you've always picked Natasha. You picked her over me when she was sixteen and wanted Broadway. You picked her over me when she married a hustler from the Westside. And you picked her baby over mine last night.

(beat)

It was never the best. It was always her.

She turns and walks out. She doesn't slam the door. She closes it softly, which is worse.

Joan and Victor sit in the silence she left behind.

JOAN

(finally)

Well. That went beautifully.

VICTOR

She'll come around.

JOAN

Victor, she's fifty-five. If she were going to come around, she'd have done it by now.

Victor sits back down, heavily. He picks up the newspaper again. He doesn't read it.

VICTOR

Then she'll go around. The long way.
Like she always does.

The door opens a crack. Winston's head appears.

WINSTON

Sir. Madam. The Congresswoman's car has left. And the florists would like to know if the peacocks are staying.

VICTOR

Where would they go, Winston?

WINSTON

The florists suggested Monaco, sir.

JOAN

(despite everything,
laughing)

Leave the birds. Somebody in this family should get to scream in peace.

WINSTON

(bowing out)
Very good, madam.

CUT TO:

4. INT. WESTBROOK ACADEMY - MAIN HALLWAY - MORNING (8:10 AM)

A private school that looks like a small Ivy League campus: oak paneling, trophy cases, portraits of distinguished alumni. STUDENTS in navy blazers flood the hall between classes.

Near the drama department, a crowd of eighth-graders has gathered around a glossy poster on the bulletin board.

Emma and Victoria push through the crowd. Lyric is already there at the front, reading it.

INSERT - THE POSTER

A gold crown on a black background. Elegant type:

"DONOHUE PICTURES PRESENTS: CROWNS. An original movie musical. Written and directed by Marc-Anthony Bullock. OPEN CASTING: Three lead roles, ages 13 to 15. Self-tapes due Thursday, January 15. Parental consent required."

BACK TO SCENE

VICTORIA
(breathless)
Oh. My. God.

EMMA
(reading it again)
"Written and directed by Marc-Anthony Bullock."

LYRIC
(bouncing)
He's been writing it for two years.
There's a scene on a rooftop where the
three girls sing to the whole city and
it made me cry when he read it to me
and I don't even cry at movies.

VICTORIA
You cried at the cooking show where
the cake fell over.

LYRIC
That was a very sad cake.

A new voice from behind them.

TREY (O.S.)
Let me guess. You're all going to try
out.

LEONARD "TREY" SMILLEY III (13; blazer worn open, loafers without socks, the swagger of a boy whose last name is on a building) leans against the lockers with two friends.

VICTORIA

Go away, Trey.

TREY

I'm your cousin. I'm legally allowed to be anywhere you are.

EMMA

That's not how the law works.

TREY

(to Lyric, suddenly a little less smooth)
Hey, Lyric.

LYRIC

(a little too casual)
Hey, Trey.

VICTORIA

(noticing, delighted)
Oh, no.

TREY

(recovering, to the twins)
You know Grandpa Gus would literally explode, right? A Smilley in a Donohue movie?

EMMA

Nobody said we were trying out.

TREY

Victoria's already practicing her face.

VICTORIA

This is my regular face.

TREY

That's the face you made when you got the solo in the Christmas concert.

VICTORIA
Because I was good!

TREY
(shrugging, walking off)
Whatever. I'm just saying. The
Smilleys don't work for the Donohues.
It's, like, a rule.

He goes. Lyric watches him go, just a second too long.
Victoria elbows her.

VICTORIA
(sing-song)
Lyric likes Trey.

LYRIC
I don't like Trey. Trey wears loafers
without socks. That's a red flag.

EMMA
(still staring at the
poster)
He's right, though.

VICTORIA
Trey's never right.

EMMA
About Mom. You saw her this morning.
You say one word about the Donohues
and she looks like she swallowed a
bee.

(beat)
Mom will never allow it.

VICTORIA
(eyes on the poster, the
Marc-Anthony grin spreading
across her face)
Mom won't know.

The bell rings. The hallway empties around them. Emma
looks at her sister. Her sister looks at the crown.

CUT TO:

5. INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - HOMICIDE SQUAD ROOM - DAY (9:00 AM)

A long room of desks, whiteboards, and bad coffee. Jeremy stands at a whiteboard where a DMV photo of Terrence Gaines is taped next to the words ARCHITECT = ? in blue marker.

Rosa sits on the edge of a desk. Elxa stands in the doorway in her uniform, reading the ID sheet.

ELXA
Terrence Gaines.

JEREMY
You know him?

ELXA
(beat)
I know the name. Westside. He ran with some people I used to have files on when I was in Homicide. Never enough to charge.

ROSA
The gun charge in '19. Dismissed.
Guess who his lawyer was.

She holds up a printout. Elxa takes it. Reads it.

Her face doesn't change. But she hands it back a little too fast.

ELXA
Bullock and Associates.

JEREMY
Your father's firm.

ELXA
My father's firm represents half the people who've ever been arrested in this city, Jeremy. It's not a clue. It's a Tuesday.

JEREMY

I'm not saying it's a clue. I'm saying it's in the file.

ELXA

Then put it in the file. By the book.

(pointed)

That's what you like.

Rosa suddenly finds her coffee very interesting. Elxa turns to the whiteboard.

ELXA (CONT'D)

And this.

JEREMY

The only contact in the burner. The number's a prepaid. Bought with cash, activated six weeks ago, no name on the account. It's off right now.

ELXA

So it's a dead end.

JEREMY

It's a door. I want a warrant for the carrier. Tower records, call history, every ping. If that phone ever wakes up, I want to know where it's sleeping.

ELXA

How long?

JEREMY

Judge Okoye's on duty. If I get it to her by noon, maybe two days.

ROSA

Two days. A man was strangled, and we're waiting on paperwork.

JEREMY

Paperwork is how we put the guy away instead of watching him walk.

ELXA

(beat)

Do it. And I'm giving a statement at two. Name, age, a request for information. Nothing about the phone.

JEREMY

Nothing about the phone.

ELXA

And nothing about "Architect." If the press gets a name like that, they'll have it trending by dinner.

She goes. Rosa waits until she's out of earshot.

ROSA

Your wife just got very interested in not being interested.

JEREMY

(staring at the whiteboard)

Yeah.

(beat)

I noticed.

He picks up a marker and, under ARCHITECT = ?, writes a single word: BELMONT?

Then he stares at it. And erases it with his thumb.

ROSA

Why'd you erase it?

JEREMY

Because it's a guess. And the last man in this department who wrote his guesses on a whiteboard was my father.

ROSA

And?

JEREMY

(beat)

And he was usually right. That's what scared everybody.

ACT TWO**6. INT. DONOHUE TOWER - NATASHA'S OFFICE - DAY (9:30 AM)**

Bloomberg-style screens show a stock chart: DNHU +6.1%. Natasha, at her desk, is on speakerphone with a BOARD MEMBER. Robert sits across from her eating her almonds.

BOARD MEMBER (V.O.)

...and the Congresswoman called me at six-fifteen this morning, Natasha. Six-fifteen. She wanted to know if the board had "formally ratified" the appointment.

NATASHA

And what did you tell her?

BOARD MEMBER (V.O.)

I told her the board voted unanimously on December nineteenth and she should check her mail.

NATASHA

(a small, satisfied smile)

Thank you, Harrison.

BOARD MEMBER (V.O.)

She called three other directors after me.

NATASHA

Then I'm sure she's having a lovely morning. Thank you, Harrison.

She hangs up. Robert whistles.

ROBERT

Six-fifteen.

NATASHA

My sister's been up since four. She does her best work before sunrise, like a vampire in a St. John suit.

ROBERT

You want me to call her?

NATASHA

God, no. You're the last person she wants to hear from. You're the hustler from the Westside.

ROBERT

(delighted)

She still calls me that?

NATASHA

Every Thanksgiving.

ROBERT

I love that woman. She's the only person in this family who's never once pretended to like me.

On the muted TV in the corner, a BNN crawl scrolls: ...APD IDENTIFIES MAN FOUND IN CHATTAHOOCHEE AS TERRENCE GAINES, 41...

Robert stops chewing. He reaches for the remote. Unmutes it.

BNN ANCHOR (ON TV) ...Police have identified the man pulled from the Chattahoochee River early Monday morning as forty-one-year-old Terrence Gaines of Atlanta. Chief Elxa Jackson is expected to make a statement this afternoon...

Robert mutes it again. He looks at the screen for a moment.

NATASHA

You know him.

ROBERT

Knew him. I got him off a gun charge in 2019. Illegal search. The arresting officer forgot the Fourth Amendment was in the Constitution.

NATASHA

Was he guilty?

ROBERT

Baby, they're all guilty. That's not the question. The question is whether the government can prove it without cheating.

NATASHA

And couldn't they?

ROBERT

(beat)

They could have. I cheated better.

Natasha looks at him over her reading glasses.

NATASHA

Robert.

ROBERT

I'm kidding.

(beat)

Mostly.

He stands and buttons his jacket. The joke fades from his face.

He stops at the door, turns back.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

Does Marc know you're throwing him a welcome breakfast Thursday?

NATASHA

It's not a breakfast. It's an all-hands. Four thousand employees in the atrium, a live feed to every Donohue office on the planet.

ROBERT

With pastries?

NATASHA

With pastries.

ROBERT

Then it's a breakfast, Tasha. Don't lie to a lawyer about pastries.

NATASHA

(picking up her phone,
dialing)

Go away, Robert.

(into phone)

Baby. It's your mother... No, I'm not calling to check on you... Fine, I'm calling to check on you. Thursday, eight a.m. The atrium. Wear the gray suit, not the blue one, the blue one makes you look like a magician... Because I said so. Because I'm your CEO. Because I carried you for nine months and you kicked like a mule... I love you too.

She hangs up. Robert is still in the doorway, smiling.

ROBERT

The blue one's nice.

NATASHA

The blue one is for birthdays.

Robert's smile fades. He looks at the muted TV again.

ROBERT (CONT'D)

T-Bone was a sweetheart. Big guy, soft voice. Brought my secretary flowers after the case was dismissed. He knew some very bad people and he was very loyal to them.

NATASHA

Loyal people don't usually end up in the river.

ROBERT

No.

(heading for the door)

Loyal people who stop being loyal do.

CUT TO:

7. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - HOME GYM - DAY (10:00 AM)

A private gym with floor-to-ceiling windows over the ridge. Heavy bags, a boxing ring, a wall of mirrors.

Marc, in a gray T-shirt and hand wraps, works a heavy bag alone. He's good. Fast. Precise. Every combination lands in the same place. The bag swings back, and he hits it again.

Amond enters in a coat, still holding his car keys. He doesn't say anything. He doesn't have to. Marc sees his face in the mirror and stops.

The bag swings. Creaks. Stops.

MARC-ANTHONY

Say it.

AMOND

It's him. APD ID'd him this morning.
It's on BNN.

MARC-ANTHONY

(quiet)

T-Bone.

AMOND

Terrence Gaines. Forty-one. They're
saying he was strangled.

Marc unwinds the wrap from his right hand slowly, turn by turn.

MARC-ANTHONY

He had a daughter.

AMOND

Two. Eight and eleven.

MARC-ANTHONY

And a mother on Simpson Road who makes the best peach cobbler in Atlanta. He brought one to my house on the Fourth of July once and pretended he made it himself.

AMOND

I remember.

MARC-ANTHONY

He used to call me "Mr. Marc" at the Club like we'd never met. Always so respectful. Always so careful.

(beat)

He wasn't careful enough.

AMOND

Or somebody got to him.

Marc tosses the wrap into a bin. He sits down on the edge of the ring. For a moment he's just a man who lost somebody.

MARC-ANTHONY

The girls. The mother. The envelope goes out Friday. Rent for a year. Tuition, if they want it. Nobody says where it came from.

AMOND

It's already done.

MARC-ANTHONY

(looking up)

Already?

AMOND

I've known you twenty-nine years. I know what you're going to say before you say it.

Marc almost smiles.

MARC-ANTHONY

Then tell me what I'm going to say next.

AMOND

(beat)

"Who did this."

MARC-ANTHONY

Who did this.

AMOND

Nobody knows. Nobody's talking. Nobody in our house, nobody in Morrow's house. That's what scares me. Usually somebody brags.

MARC-ANTHONY

Nobody bragged because whoever did it didn't do it for business.

(beat)

The medical examiner says bare hands. That's personal. That's somebody who wanted to look at him while he did it.

AMOND

How do you know what the M.E. said?

MARC-ANTHONY

(standing, pulling on a hoodie)

Because I know what the M.E. said.

Amond doesn't push it. He's known him twenty-nine years.

Marc studies his friend.

MARC-ANTHONY

What happened on the terrace last night?

AMOND

Nothing.

MARC-ANTHONY

You came back in holding her wineglass
like it was a baby bird.

AMOND

She handed it to me.

MARC-ANTHONY

And then?

AMOND

And then she walked away. Like always.

(beat)

And then your cousin bought me a
scotch.

MARC-ANTHONY

(surprised)

Martin?

AMOND

Said some things. About standing in
the back of the room.

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat, lightly)

And what did you say?

AMOND

I said I stand where I always stand.

In Amond's coat pocket, out of Marc's sight, his fingers
find the edge of a business card and stop there.

MARC-ANTHONY

(grinning)

Right next to me, being handsome and
underappreciated.

AMOND

(grinning back, a beat
late)

Exactly.

AMOND

Your sister's got the case.

MARC-ANTHONY

My brother-in-law has the case. My
sister has the headache.

AMOND

Same thing in your family.

MARC-ANTHONY

(grabbing a water bottle)

Everything's the same thing in my
family. That's the whole problem.

CUT TO:

8. INT. OLSON ESTATE - FOYER - DAY (10:45 AM)

Marble and brass. Jasmine comes in through the front door
and nearly collides with Peter, who is heading out in his
surgeon's coat, keys in hand.

PETER

How'd it go?

JASMINE

(tossing her gloves on the
hall table)

Beautifully. My father told me I've
been sitting down for fifty-five
years.

PETER

You told me you were going to stand.

JASMINE

I stood. He sat. It didn't help.

She drops her briefcase. Stands in the foyer, arms
crossed, staring at nothing. Peter sets down his keys.

JASMINE (CONT'D)

He said something. At the end.

PETER

What?

JASMINE

He said there are things about my son
I don't want to know.

Peter's face gives nothing away. He's a surgeon. He's very good at that.

PETER

He was angry. He says things.

JASMINE

He said, "Ask Martin what he does with
his hands when nobody's watching."

(beat)

What does that mean, Peter?

A long moment. Peter looks at his wife. He thinks of the gauze. The stitches. The two a.m. knock at his clinic's back door.

He picks his keys back up.

PETER

It means he's seventy-nine and he's
still playing chess. He wanted you
rattled, and you're rattled.

JASMINE

You're sure?

PETER

(kissing her cheek)

I'm a surgeon, Jazz. I'm sure about
everything.

He heads for the door. Stops. Doesn't turn around.

PETER (CONT'D)

Don't ask Martin about his hands.

JASMINE

Why not?

PETER

(beat)

Because it's what your father wants.

He goes. Jasmine stands alone in the foyer. She looks up the grand staircase toward the second floor, toward the hallway where her son's old bedroom still waits.

CUT TO:

9. INT. CONGRESSWOMAN OLSON'S DISTRICT OFFICE - DAY (11:15 AM)

A storefront office on Cascade Road: flags, framed photos of Jasmine with three decades of presidents and preachers, a wall of constituent thank-you cards. Phones ringing. INTERNS answering them.

In the back office, Jasmine hangs her coat on the door, finally. Her chief of staff, BEVERLY "BEV" HOLLAND (60; reading glasses on a beaded chain, twenty-nine years at Jasmine's side, afraid of nothing), follows her in with a stack of messages.

BEV

Forty-one calls since eight o'clock.
Nineteen are congratulations for
Marc-Anthony.

JASMINE

Delete them.

BEV

Twelve are reporters asking how you
feel about Marc-Anthony.

JASMINE

Delete them twice.

BEV

And one is a State Senator named
Marcus Pryor, asking if you have ten
minutes next week "to discuss the
future of the district."

Jasmine stops.

JASMINE

Pryor.

BEV

He's been shaking hands at every church on the south side since Christmas. Pastor Lewis at Greater Hope says he gave a "very inspiring prayer" on Sunday.

JASMINE

He's a thirty-something lawyer with good teeth and a donor list somebody else wrote for him.

BEV

He's forty-five.

JASMINE

(beat)

Then he's a forty-five-year-old lawyer with good teeth.

(sitting)

Who's paying for him?

BEV

Nobody knows yet.

JASMINE

Find out.

BEV

Jasmine. Can I say something as your friend and not your employee?

JASMINE

You've never once said anything as my employee.

BEV

(sitting across from her)

The morning your father puts your sister's boy on the throne, a man starts calling about "the future of the district." That's not a coincidence. That's a smell.

JASMINE

You think somebody's using my father's announcement to make me look weak.

BEV

I think this is the first morning in twenty-nine years you've looked like you could lose.

Jasmine takes off her glasses. She looks at the wall of photographs: Jasmine at twenty-six, sworn in. Jasmine with a president. Jasmine at a funeral for a civil rights legend, holding his widow's hand.

JASMINE

(quiet)

I've never lost, Bev.

BEV

I know.

JASMINE

Not a race. Not a vote. Not a fight.

BEV

I know.

JASMINE

(putting her glasses back on, all business again)

Then call Pastor Lewis. Call every pastor on the south side. Call the union halls, the sororities, the barbershops. I want to know every hand that man has shaken since Christmas.

BEV

(rising)

And Pryor's ten minutes?

JASMINE

Tell him I'll give him five. And tell him to bring the donor list.

(beat)

I'd like to see whose handwriting it's
in.

ACT THREE**10. INT. DONOHUE BROADCASTING GROUP - MARTIN'S OFFICE -
DAY (11:30 AM)**

A corner office in the DBG building in Midtown: a wall of monitors showing every channel Donohue owns, all of them muted. Martin sits at his desk in shirtsleeves, black glove on his right hand. Replays of last night's gala play on three screens.

On one monitor, again and again: Victor on the landing. "Effective immediately..." Applause. Then Martin's own glass, shattering in his hand.

He watches it without expression.

On another screen, BNN. The same crawl: APD IDENTIFIES MAN FOUND IN CHATTAHOOCHEE AS TERRENCE GAINES, 41.

Martin's eyes move to it. They stay there a moment.

He picks up the remote, and turns that screen off. Just that one.

His desk phone buzzes. He presses the speaker.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)

Mr. Olson, your mother on line one.

MARTIN

Put her through.

(click)

Good morning, Mother.

JASMINE (V.O.)

I just came from your grandfather.

MARTIN

And how is the King this morning?

JASMINE (V.O.)

He's giving interviews to the Beacon about "the future." He called me emotional.

MARTIN

You are emotional.

JASMINE (V.O.)

Martin.

MARTIN

It's a compliment. You're the only one
in this family who still feels things
out loud.

A pause on the line.

JASMINE (V.O.)

He said something about you.

Martin's gloved hand stops on the desk.

MARTIN

(lightly)

Did he.

JASMINE (V.O.)

He said I should ask you what you do
with your hands when nobody's
watching.

Martin looks down at the black glove. He flexes the
fingers slowly.

MARTIN

(easy, warm)

I type, Mother. I sign contracts.
Sometimes I hold a very good glass of
scotch.

(beat)

Occasionally I break one.

JASMINE (V.O.)

(a small, relieved laugh)

That's what your father said. Chess.

MARTIN

Grandfather's been playing chess
against this family since before any
of us were born. Let him have his win.

JASMINE (V.O.)

And then?

MARTIN

And then it's our move.

He hangs up. Sits back. On the muted screen, his glass shatters again, on a loop, over and over.

Martin smiles at it.

CUT TO:

11. INT. WESTBROOK ACADEMY - CAFETERIA - DAY (12:15 PM)

A sunny dining hall with long wooden tables and a salad bar that looks like a farmers' market. Emma, Victoria, and Lyric huddle at the end of a table, heads close, lunch untouched.

Victoria has a notebook open. Across the top, in purple gel pen: OPERATION CROWN.

VICTORIA

Step one. Self-tape. We need a camera, a quiet room, and a monologue.

EMMA

We need a parent's signature.

VICTORIA

That's step four.

EMMA

It's the only step. It says "parental consent required" in bold letters. On a poster. In a school.

LYRIC

(carefully)

He's really strict about that. Uncle Marc. He says kids on sets have to be protected. He doesn't even let me stay past nine.

VICTORIA

Then we'll get consent.

EMMA

From who? Mom? Mom won't even let us say his name in the house.

VICTORIA

From Mom's signature.

Emma and Lyric both stare at her.

EMMA

Tori.

VICTORIA

What? I'm not saying we'd do anything. I'm saying Mom signs things all day. She signs field trips and permission slips and, like, billion-dollar contracts. Her signature is everywhere.

EMMA

That's forgery. That's an actual crime.

VICTORIA

It's not a crime if it's for art.

LYRIC

That's definitely still a crime.

VICTORIA

(to Lyric)

You're auditioning, right?

LYRIC

(beat)

Uncle Marc says I have to audition like everybody else. He says it's not fair if I don't.

EMMA

He's making his own goddaughter audition?

LYRIC

He's very weird about fair.

Victoria taps the notebook.

VICTORIA

See? Fair. Anybody can try. It's an open call. And we're anybody.

EMMA

We're not anybody. We're Smilleys.

VICTORIA

(leaning in, fierce)

Emma. When was the last time you felt like you were exactly where you're supposed to be?

Emma doesn't answer.

VICTORIA (CONT'D)

I felt it last night. Through the door. Watching him on Mom's laptop in the crack. I felt it like my whole body was a tuning fork.

EMMA

(quiet)

I felt it too.

VICTORIA

So?

EMMA

(beat, then firm)

So we'd get caught.

VICTORIA

Mom won't know.

EMMA

Mom always knows.

LYRIC

(gently)

Not always.

Both twins look at her.

LYRIC (CONT'D)

My mom didn't know about my first audition either. I told her after I booked it.

(beat)

She cried. But the good kind.

Victoria grins. Emma bites her lip. She looks at the purple letters across the top of the page. OPERATION CROWN.

EMMA

(finally)

We're just going to film it. That's all. Just to see.

VICTORIA

(triumphant)

Just to see.

EMMA

And if it's bad, we delete it.

VICTORIA

It won't be bad.

EMMA

How do you know?

VICTORIA

(that grin)

Because we're us.

CUT TO:

12. INT. HARMONY'S APARTMENT - ADAMSVILLE - DAY (1:00 PM)

Harmony, in sweatpants and a headwrap, edits a wedding video on a laptop at the kitchen table. On screen, a groom cries at an altar. She yawns. Clicks. Trims. Yawns again.

On a second laptop beside it, the pink-and-black Tea Kettle dashboard glows: 3.4 MILLION VIEWS.

A knock on the door.

Harmony slams the second laptop shut and shoves it under a sofa cushion.

HARMONY

Who is it?

AMOND (O.S.)

It's the man who brings you food.

HARMONY

(closing her eyes)

Of course it is.

She opens the door. Amond stands there in a cashmere overcoat holding a paper bag that smells like heaven.

AMOND

Lemon pepper wings. Extra flats. Blue cheese, not ranch, because you're not an animal.

HARMONY

We're on a break.

AMOND

The wings aren't on a break. The wings love you unconditionally.

She lets him in. She takes the bag. She is not going to smile. She absolutely is going to smile.

AMOND (CONT'D)

(looking at the laptop)

Who's that?

HARMONY

A dentist from Marietta and his third wife. I'm cutting the father of the bride's speech from eleven minutes to four.

AMOND

Why?

HARMONY

Because seven of those minutes are
about his boat.

Amond laughs. He sits on the arm of the sofa, right above
the cushion hiding the laptop. Harmony freezes. He doesn't
notice.

AMOND

You see the Kettle this morning?

HARMONY

(too casual)

The what?

AMOND

The Tea Kettle ATL. The blog.
Everybody reads it.

HARMONY

I don't read gossip. I make art.

AMOND

You make wedding videos about boats.

HARMONY

Currently.

AMOND

(pulling out his phone)

Somebody saw Martin cut his hand. "The
blood matched his gloves." And there's
a thing about Esther.

(beat)

Whoever writes that thing was at the
party last night, Harm. They were in
the room.

HARMONY

(unwrapping a wing, not
looking at him)

Probably a waiter.

AMOND

A waiter with two million followers?

HARMONY

Waiters are very observant. People
forget they have eyes.

Amond shrugs. Puts his phone away.

AMOND

Lyric's speech. Last night.

HARMONY

(softening, despite
herself)

Yeah.

AMOND

She's so good, Harm. She's so good it
scares me.

HARMONY

She gets that from me.

AMOND

She gets everything from you.

(beat)

That's not the problem, you know. It's
never been the problem.

Harmony puts the wing down. She looks at him, the man in
the cashmere coat sitting in her tiny apartment like it's
the only place he wants to be.

HARMONY

You should go.

AMOND

I just got here.

HARMONY

I know. That's why you should go.

AMOND

(standing, gentle)

Okay.

He heads for the door. Stops.

AMOND (CONT'D)

The wings are still hot. Eat them
before they get sad.

He leaves. The door clicks shut.

Harmony sits very still. Then she reaches under the sofa cushion, pulls out the second laptop, and opens it. The view counter: 3.7 MILLION.

She looks at the door. She looks at the number.

She eats a wing.

The laptop chimes. A new message in the Kettle inbox, from an anonymous account named PETALPUSHER_ATL.

INSERT - LAPTOP SCREEN

"Kettle. Florist here. Was at Summit House this AM hauling roses. 8:15, the Congresswoman stormed in without taking her coat off. Left 20 min later. Didn't slam the door. Closed it SOFT. That's worse right??"

BACK TO SCENE

Harmony reads it twice. She wipes the lemon pepper off her fingers onto her sweatpants. And she starts to type.

HARMONY

(to herself, typing)

"Which ridge royal paid Granddaddy a
very early visit this morning, and
left without taking off her coat..."

(beat, deleting)

No. Too much.

(retyping)

"...and closed the door so softly you
could hear the family tree crack."

She smiles. It's a good line. She knows it's a good line. She hits SAVE, not publish.

HARMONY (CONT'D)
(to the screen)
Tomorrow.

ACT FOUR**13. EXT. APD HEADQUARTERS - FRONT STEPS - DAY (2:00 PM)**

A podium with the APD seal. A crowd of REPORTERS and camera crews bundled against the cold. Elxa steps up to the microphones in full dress uniform. Behind her, Jeremy and Rosa stand with their hands clasped.

ELXA

Good afternoon. At approximately six-ten a.m. on Monday, January fifth, a rower discovered the body of an adult male in the Chattahoochee River near the Paces Ferry Road bridge. The Fulton County Medical Examiner has identified him as Terrence Gaines, forty-one, of Atlanta.

(beat)

Mr. Gaines's death has been ruled a homicide. We are asking anyone who saw Mr. Gaines on the evening of Sunday, January fourth, or who has any information, to contact the Atlanta Police Department. I'll take a few questions.

A thicket of hands.

REPORTER #1 Chief, WDON. How did he die?

ELXA

I won't discuss the cause of death while the investigation is active.

REPORTER #2 Chief, Channel 7. Is it true Mr. Gaines had ties to organized crime?

ELXA

Mr. Gaines had one arrest in 2019. The charges were dismissed. I'm not going to try a dead man in the press.

A young woman in a wool coat pushes to the front, notebook in hand. JOURNEE HOLLOWAY (32; sharp eyes, no makeup, a press badge from The Peach Ledger).

JOURNEE

Chief, Journee Holloway, The Peach Ledger. There have been at least six unsolved deaths in the last three years involving men with suspected ties to what some officers call a "ghost network." Is Mr. Gaines the seventh?

A ripple through the crowd. Behind Elxa, Jeremy's eyes flick to his wife.

ELXA

(steady)

I'm not aware of any "ghost network."
I'm aware of a man who was murdered,
and a family who deserves answers.
That's what we're working on.

JOURNEE

Your department's own files use the term, Chief. You used it yourself, as a lieutenant in Homicide.

A beat. Elxa looks at the reporter for a long moment.

ELXA

Thank you. That's all for today.

She steps away from the podium. The reporters shout after her. She walks up the steps and through the doors without turning around.

Jeremy and Rosa follow.

ROSA

(under her breath, to
Jeremy)

"I'm not aware of any ghost network."

JEREMY
(under his breath)
I heard.

ROSA
She named it. In her own files. You
told me.

JEREMY
(sharp)
Delgado.

ROSA
I'm just saying. She's a very good
liar for a cop.

Jeremy doesn't answer. He watches his wife's back as she
disappears into the building.

At the bottom of the steps, the reporters pack up. Journee
Holloway lingers. When Jeremy comes back out a minute
later for a smoke break he doesn't take, she's waiting.

JOURNEE
Detective Jackson.

JEREMY
No comment.

JOURNEE
I didn't ask anything.

JEREMY
You were about to.

JOURNEE
(holding out a business
card)
I was about to give you this.

He looks at it. Doesn't take it.

JOURNEE (CONT'D)

Six men in three years, Detective.
Every one of them from the same few
blocks. Every one of them with a
lawyer he couldn't afford. Every case
closed, or cold, or quiet.

(beat)

I'm not asking you to say anything.
I'm asking you to call me when
somebody tells you to stop looking.

JEREMY

Nobody's going to tell me to stop
looking.

JOURNEE

(gently)

Then you'll never need the card.

She tucks it into the breast pocket of his coat herself,
pats it once, and walks away.

Jeremy stands on the steps. He takes the card out and
reads it.

JOURNEE HOLLOWAY. THE PEACH LEDGER. A cell number,
handwritten.

He puts it back in his pocket.

CUT TO:

14. EXT. SUMMIT HOUSE - ROSE GARDEN - DAY (2:30 PM)

A formal winter garden: clipped boxwoods, bare rose canes
wrapped in burlap, a stone fountain turned off for the
season. Joan and Victor walk the gravel path arm in arm,
both in long coats.

A peacock struts past them with enormous self-importance.

VICTOR

Where did Alvin even get peacocks in
January?

JOAN

Your son could get a peacock on the moon if there was a party there.

VICTOR

My son can't get himself on a plane to his own nephew's birthday.

JOAN

He sent birds.

VICTOR

He sent noise.

They walk in silence.

JOAN

You were cruel to her this morning.

VICTOR

I was accurate.

JOAN

You can be both, Victor. You usually are.

VICTOR

(stopping)

She came into my study and told me I'd always chosen Natasha over her.

JOAN

Haven't you?

Victor looks at his wife.

JOAN (CONT'D)

Not in love, darling. In faith. You loved them both the same. But you always believed Natasha could do anything and you always worried Jasmine couldn't. And children feel the difference. They always feel it.

VICTOR

(quiet)

Jasmine is the strongest of all of them.

JOAN

Then tell her that. Just once. Before she spends the rest of her life proving it to you in all the wrong ways.

Victor looks down at the frozen fountain.

VICTOR

Did you see his hand last night, Joan?

JOAN

Martin's? He cut it on the glass.

VICTOR

He was wearing gloves before he picked up the glass. At breakfast. At the carpet. All night long.

(beat)

A man doesn't wear gloves to a party unless he's hiding something underneath them.

JOAN

(uneasy)

Victor. He's our grandson.

VICTOR

So was the boy he pushed down my stairs.

A peacock SCREAMS behind them. Joan startles. Victor doesn't.

CUT TO:

15. INT. SMILLEY PLAZA - ESTHER'S OFFICE - DAY (3:00 PM)

A corner office on the fortieth floor of Smilley Plaza in Buckhead. White marble, white orchids, a white desk. Through the windows, across the treetops, the needle of Donohue Tower rises in the distance.

Esther stands at the window, arms crossed, looking at it. On her desk, her assistant has left a printout of the Tea Kettle post with a sticky note: "FYI. Do you want PR to respond?"

She crumples it and drops it in the wastebasket.

She crosses to her desk, unlocks the bottom drawer with a small gold key from her bracelet, and takes out a slim leather folder.

She opens it. Inside, a single photograph, face down. She hesitates. She turns it over.

INSERT - THE PHOTOGRAPH

A Polaroid, slightly faded. A lake at night, string lights over a boat dock. A girl of eighteen in a gold dress, barefoot, laughing, her face half-turned from the camera. Beside her, out of focus, the blurred profile of a young man in a white shirt.

Handwritten on the white border: LANIER. 9/3/11.

BACK TO SCENE

Esther looks at it for a long time. She doesn't cry. She's past crying about this. She just looks.

Her cell phone vibrates on the desk. She flips the photo face down, fast. The screen reads: HARMONY.

She answers.

ESTHER

I'm working.

HARMONY (V.O.)

You're looking out the window at Donohue Tower.

ESTHER

(beat)

How could you possibly know that?

HARMONY (V.O.)

Because it's three o'clock and it's sunny and you do it every day at three o'clock when it's sunny.

ESTHER

I do not.

HARMONY (V.O.)

You've done it since Smilley Plaza opened, Esther. You were four.

Esther turns her back on the window, very deliberately.

ESTHER

What do you want?

HARMONY (V.O.)

Lyric says there's a casting call at Westbrook. For his movie.

ESTHER

(cold)

I heard.

HARMONY (V.O.)

She says the girls saw the poster.

ESTHER

The girls see a lot of posters.

HARMONY (V.O.)

She says Victoria stood in front of it like it was the Mona Lisa.

A long pause. Esther closes her eyes.

ESTHER

They're thirteen. Thirteen-year-olds want to be in movies. Next month it'll be horses.

HARMONY (V.O.)
(carefully)
Esther. What if they're good?

ESTHER
They are good. They're extraordinary.
That's not the point.

HARMONY (V.O.)
Then what is?

ESTHER
(beat)
Not with him. Anyone but him.

A silence on the line. When Harmony speaks again, her voice is softer than it's been in years.

HARMONY (V.O.)
Okay.

ESTHER
Okay?

HARMONY (V.O.)
Okay. I'm just your friend. I'm not
your conscience.

ESTHER
You're both.

HARMONY (V.O.)
Only on weekends.

The line goes dead. Esther looks at the phone. Then at the Polaroid, face down on the desk.

Her desk phone buzzes. She flips the photo face down, fast.

ASSISTANT (V.O.)
Ms. Smilley, your father's office. He
wants the whole family at Smilley
Plaza tomorrow at nine. He says it's
about Donohue.

Esther's face goes cold and smooth. The heiress again.

ESTHER
(pressing the button)
Tell my father I'll be there.

She slides the Polaroid back into the folder, the folder into the drawer, and turns the key.

ACT FIVE**16. INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - DIGITAL FORENSICS LAB - DAY
(4:30 PM)**

A windowless lab full of servers, workbenches, and phones in evidence bags. OFFICER DEVON MARSH (20s; hoodie over his uniform shirt, three energy drinks on his desk) spins in his chair to face Jeremy and Rosa.

DEVON

So the good news is the call log
wasn't wiped. It was deleted.

ROSA

What's the difference?

DEVON

Wiped is gone. Deleted is hiding. Your
guy hit "clear history," which is what
my grandma does when she doesn't want
my grandpa seeing her shopping-channel
orders. It's all still on the chip.

JEREMY

Show me.

Devon turns his monitor toward them. A list of dates and times.

DEVON

Fourteen outgoing calls to the
Architect number over the last six
weeks. All short. Under a minute. Like
he was checking in. Or asking
permission.

(scrolling)

And one more.

He highlights the last line.

DEVON (CONT'D)

Sunday, January fourth, nine
forty-seven p.m. Outgoing to
Architect. Duration: zero seconds.

JEREMY

Zero?

DEVON

Didn't connect. Rang out, or got
rejected.

ROSA

Two hours before he died. He called
his boss, and his boss didn't pick up.

JEREMY

We don't know it's his boss.

ROSA

Jackson, a guy with one contact in his
secret phone named "Architect." That's
his boss.

JEREMY

Or his buyer. Or his dealer. Or his
priest.

ROSA

His priest doesn't need a burner.

DEVON

Some priests do. I'm just saying. I've
seen things.

Jeremy stares at the screen.

JEREMY

Any incoming calls? From the Architect
number?

DEVON

Not one. Your guy called out. Nobody
ever called in.

(beat)

Whoever this Architect is, they don't call people. People call them.

JEREMY

If that phone ever turns back on. If it ever rings. Could you tell where it is?

DEVON

Me? No. The carrier? Yes. Every time a phone rings, it talks to the nearest tower. The tower writes it down. Time, sector, signal strength.

(beat)

Get me a warrant and a ring, and I'll get you a neighborhood.

JEREMY

A neighborhood.

DEVON

Maybe a few blocks, if the towers are close together. Out in the suburbs, it's more like a zip code.

ROSA

(to Jeremy)

So all we need is for it to ring.

JEREMY

(warning)

All we need is a warrant.

CUT TO:

17. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY - DAY (5:00 PM)

Late sun through the glass. Marc sits at his desk reading a thick script with CROWNS on the cover, making notes in the margins with his grandfather's fountain pen. Amond sits on the leather sofa, scrolling through his phone.

AMOND

Seven hundred and twelve self-tapes.

MARC-ANTHONY

What?

AMOND

For Crowns. The casting office emailed. The poster went up in forty schools this morning. Seven hundred and twelve submissions before lunch.

MARC-ANTHONY

(delighted)

Seven hundred?

AMOND

And twelve. One of them is a thirty-five-year-old man from Ohio who "identifies as a teenage girl for the purposes of this audition."

MARC-ANTHONY

Put him in the maybe pile.

AMOND

Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY

He showed initiative. I respect initiative.

The study door bursts open. Lyric, in her Westbrook uniform, comes in with her backpack still on.

LYRIC

Uncle Marc, the poster's at school.

MARC-ANTHONY

I know. I put it there. Well, a man named Gerald put it there. I paid Gerald.

LYRIC

Everybody saw it. Everybody. Even the eighth-grade boys who pretend they don't care about anything.

MARC-ANTHONY

Good.

LYRIC
(casual, too casual)
Emma and Victoria saw it.

Marc looks up from the script.

MARC-ANTHONY
The Smilley girls?

LYRIC
They want to try out.

MARC-ANTHONY
(laughing)
Their mother would set me on fire.

LYRIC
That's what Emma said.

MARC-ANTHONY
What did Victoria say?

LYRIC
(beat)
Victoria said their mom won't know.

Marc laughs even harder. Amond shakes his head.

MARC-ANTHONY
I like Victoria. Victoria's got a
plan.

AMOND
Victoria's got a lawsuit.

MARC-ANTHONY
(to Lyric, suddenly more
serious)
Listen. Every kid who sends a tape
gets the same shot. Every single one.
But nobody gets on my set without a
parent saying yes. That's not a rule,
Lyric. That's a law. That's my law.

LYRIC
I know.

MARC-ANTHONY

So if those girls want to audition,
they'd better talk to their mother.

LYRIC

(heading out)

Their mother won't even let them say
your name.

The door closes behind her. Marc sits back in his chair.

MARC-ANTHONY

(half to himself)

What did I ever do to Esther Smilley?

AMOND

You're a Donohue.

MARC-ANTHONY

I've never even met her.

AMOND

You've been in the same room with her.

MARC-ANTHONY

(thinking)

Have I?

AMOND

Galas. Fundraisers. Somebody's wedding
in 2016. She leaves every room you
walk into.

MARC-ANTHONY

(frowning)

Every room?

AMOND

Every single one. Everybody's noticed
except you.

Marc looks out the window, across the ridge, toward the
lights beginning to come on in Tuxedo Park.

MARC-ANTHONY

You know what, that's rude. I'm
delightful in a room. I'm the best
thing that ever happens to a room.
Rooms write me thank-you notes.

AMOND

Maybe she's allergic.

MARC-ANTHONY

To what?

AMOND

(shrugging)

You. It's in the Kettle. "Some
allergies run deep."

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)

I thought that was about the Smilleys
in general.

AMOND

Maybe it is.

MARC-ANTHONY

(half to himself)

Maybe it isn't.

MARC-ANTHONY

Huh.

CUT TO:

**18. INT. OLSON ESTATE - PETER'S HOME OFFICE - EARLY
EVENING (6:00 PM)**

Dark wood, medical journals, a skeleton model wearing a
Morehouse cap. Peter sits alone at his desk in front of a
laptop. On screen, the patient-management system of the
Olson Facial Plastic & ENT Institute.

He scrolls to an after-hours log. One entry.

INSERT - LAPTOP SCREEN

"01/05/26, 1:58 AM. After-hours access, rear entrance. Procedure room 2. Laceration repair, right hand. Patient: M. OLSON. Attending: P. OLSON."

BACK TO SCENE

Peter looks at it for a long time. He hears the television downstairs, and Jasmine on the phone, still counting allies.

His finger hovers over the mouse.

He highlights the entry.

A dialog box: "DELETE RECORD? This action cannot be undone."

Peter closes his eyes.

He clicks YES.

A knock on the office door. Peter's hand jerks off the mouse.

JASMINE (O.S.)

Peter? Dinner's at seven. Mallory made reservations at that place with the tiny food.

PETER

(steady)

I'll be right down.

Her footsteps retreat. Peter looks back at the screen. The dialog box is still waiting.

The entry disappears. The log is empty. Peter sits in the lamplight, a surgeon who has just cut something he can never sew back.

ACT SIX**19. INT. BULLOCK ESTATE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT (7:30 PM)**

A warm, lived-in dining room: family photos, a long table, Natasha's famous short ribs. Robert carves at the head of the table. Natasha pours wine. Elxa and Jeremy sit side by side, both still in work clothes. Marc sits across from them, a napkin tucked into his collar like a child.

MARC-ANTHONY

Mama, these short ribs are a crime.

NATASHA

Thank you, baby.

MARC-ANTHONY

I mean it. Arrest them. Elxa, arrest these short ribs.

ELXA

I'm off duty.

MARC-ANTHONY

You're never off duty. You sleep with your badge on. Jeremy told me.

JEREMY

I did not.

MARC-ANTHONY

He didn't. I made that up. But look at his face. It's true.

Jeremy laughs despite himself. Natasha smiles. For a moment it's just a family dinner.

Then Robert sets down the carving knife.

ROBERT

Saw your press conference, Chief.

ELXA

(warning)

Daddy.

ROBERT

You were very good. Very calm. "I'm not going to try a dead man in the press." Excellent line. You get that from me.

ELXA

I get it from Mama.

ROBERT

(conceding)

You get it from your mother.

(beat)

I knew him, you know. Terrence.

The table goes quiet. Jeremy looks up.

ELXA

I know. It's in the file.

ROBERT

I got him off a gun charge in '19.

ELXA

Daddy, don't.

ROBERT

I'm not doing anything. I'm eating short ribs and remembering a client.

(to Jeremy)

He was a sweetheart, Detective. A big soft-spoken man who brought my secretary roses. He knew some very bad people. But he wasn't one of them.

JEREMY

(carefully)

Do you know who those people were, Mr. Bullock?

ROBERT

(smiling)

Attorney-client privilege survives death, son. Look it up.

JEREMY

I know the law, sir.

ROBERT

Then you know I can't help you.

(beat)

But I'll tell you one thing for free.
Whoever did this to him wasn't one of
his people. His people loved him.

Marc, across the table, puts down his fork. Just for a moment, he looks at his father.

Elxa catches it. She doesn't know what she caught.

NATASHA

(rising, brisk)

Who wants peach cobbler?

MARC-ANTHONY

(too quickly)

Not peach.

Everyone looks at him.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)

(recovering, grinning)

I'm on a diet. I'm thirty-four now. My
knees make noises.

NATASHA

(fond)

You're ridiculous.

MARC-ANTHONY

I'm the President of the company,
Mama. I'm ridiculous professionally
now.

The table laughs. Elxa laughs too. But she keeps watching her brother.

In the kitchen a minute later, Natasha spoons cobbler into bowls. Elxa leans against the counter with her arms crossed.

NATASHA

Your husband looks at you like a question.

ELXA

What does that mean?

NATASHA

It means he's been watching you all night like he's trying to solve you.

ELXA

He's a detective. He watches everybody like that.

NATASHA

Not like that.

(beat)

Did you two talk about babies yet?

ELXA

Mama.

NATASHA

I'm fifty-four. I'm allowed to ask one question a year.

ELXA

Every time I bring it up, he says "after the case."

NATASHA

There's always a case.

ELXA

(quietly)

That's what I said.

Natasha stops spooning. She looks at her eldest, the Chief of Police, standing in her mother's kitchen looking twelve years old.

NATASHA

Your father said "after the bar exam." Then "after I make partner." Then "after I open my own firm."

ELXA

And?

NATASHA

And then you came anyway. Before any of it. You didn't wait for anybody's "after."

(handing her a bowl)

Sometimes the best things in this family arrive early, baby. Ask your grandfather. He hated it. Look how you turned out.

Elxa laughs. It's small, but it's real. She takes the bowl.

CUT TO:

20. EXT. BULLOCK ESTATE - BACK PORCH - NIGHT (8:40 PM)

A wide stone porch overlooking the dark lawn. Robert sits in a rocking chair with a cigar he isn't supposed to have. His breath and the smoke mingle in the cold.

The screen door creaks. Marc steps out with two cups of coffee, hands one to his father, and sits in the other rocker.

ROBERT

Your mother send you out here to make me put this out?

MARC-ANTHONY

She sent me out here to see if you'd put it out.

ROBERT

And?

MARC-ANTHONY

And I'm going to tell her you did.

ROBERT

(pleased)

That's my boy.

They rock. The cold settles over them. Somewhere down the ridge a dog barks.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
You didn't want the cobbler.

MARC-ANTHONY
Diet.

ROBERT
You ate three helpings of short ribs.

MARC-ANTHONY
Protein diet.

Robert takes a slow pull on the cigar.

ROBERT
Terrence's mother used to bring peach cobbler to the courthouse. Every day of his trial. Cut it into squares on paper plates for the bailiffs, the clerks, the court reporter. Tried to give a piece to the prosecutor once.

MARC-ANTHONY
(quiet)
Did he take it?

ROBERT
He did. Then he lost.

(beat)
Best cobbler I ever had in my life.

Marc doesn't answer. He looks out at the dark.

ROBERT (CONT'D)
(still looking at the lawn,
casual)
Funny thing, you turning down cobbler tonight.

MARC-ANTHONY
(lightly)
Is it?

ROBERT

I've been cross-examining people for thirty years, son. I know what it looks like when somebody decides not to say something.

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)

And what does it look like?

ROBERT

(turning to look at him)

It looks exactly like you right now.

Marc meets his father's eyes. Then he smiles, the big warm famous smile.

MARC-ANTHONY

Daddy. I'm an actor. I decide not to say things for a living.

Robert studies him a long moment. Then he laughs, low and genuine, and taps the ash off his cigar.

ROBERT

That's what I'm afraid of.

The screen door bangs open.

NATASHA (O.S.)

Robert Bullock, I can smell that from the kitchen!

ROBERT

(stubbing it out instantly)

It's Marc's!

MARC-ANTHONY

(standing, delighted)

And there it is. Thirty years of legal training.

CUT TO:

**21. INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - TWINS' WALK-IN CLOSET - NIGHT
(9:15 PM)**

A walk-in closet the size of a studio apartment, lined with matching uniforms, sneakers, and a vanity. The door is shut. A single ring light glows on the floor.

Emma and Victoria sit cross-legged in pajamas. Between them, a stack of Esther's old permission slips, field-trip forms, and a birthday card, all signed.

Victoria has a pad of paper. On it, twenty attempts at the same signature: Esther C. Smilley.

VICTORIA
(holding up the pad)
Okay. Which one?

EMMA
(looking, reluctantly)
Number fourteen.

VICTORIA
Fourteen's good, right?

EMMA
Fourteen is scary good. That's the problem.

VICTORIA
The "E" is the whole thing. She does this loop, like she's lassoing something.

EMMA
Tori. We said just to see.

VICTORIA
I'm just seeing. I'm seeing if my hand can do it. That's not a crime. That's calligraphy.

Emma picks up the birthday card. Their mother's handwriting: "To my two whole hearts. Love you past the moon, Mom."

EMMA

(soft)

She's going to be so mad.

VICTORIA

Only if she finds out.

EMMA

She always finds out.

VICTORIA

(setting down the pen,
serious for once)

Em. Do you ever feel like there's a
room in this house we're not allowed
in?

EMMA

There are, like, forty rooms we're not
allowed in. Grandpa Gus's study.
Grandpa Leonard's wine cellar...

VICTORIA

Not a real room. A room in Mom.

Emma doesn't answer. Outside the closet door, footsteps
pass in the hallway. Both girls freeze. The footsteps keep
going. A door closes.

VICTORIA (CONT'D)

(whisper)

Every time somebody says his name, she
goes into that room and shuts the
door.

EMMA

(whisper)

Maybe she just really hates him.

VICTORIA

Maybe.

(beat)

Or maybe she really doesn't.

The girls look at each other in the ring light. Emma
reaches over, takes the pen, and, very slowly and

carefully, writes the signature herself.

Esther C. Smilley.

It's perfect.

EMMA
(staring at it)
Oh no.

VICTORIA
(delighted)
You're better than me!

A KNOCK on the closet door. Both girls jump.

ESTHER (O.S.)
Girls? Lights out was twenty minutes ago.

Victoria shoves the pad under a pile of sweaters. Emma sits on the permission slips.

VICTORIA
(sweetly)
We're picking out outfits for tomorrow!

ESTHER (O.S.)
You wear uniforms.

VICTORIA
We're picking out which uniform!

A pause on the other side of the door. The girls hold their breath.

ESTHER (O.S.)
(softer)
I love you. Both of you. You know that?

The twins look at each other. Something in their mother's voice.

EMMA
(quiet)
We know, Mom.

ESTHER (O.S.)
Bed.

Her footsteps go. The girls exhale. Emma looks down at the page in her lap with the perfect signature on it.

EMMA
(tearing the page out,
balling it up)
Nobody saw that.

VICTORIA
(grinning)
I definitely saw that.

CUT TO:

**22. INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - HOMICIDE SQUAD ROOM - NIGHT
(9:38 PM)**

The room is empty except for Jeremy and Rosa. Desk lamps. Takeout containers. The whiteboard: T-BONE, ARCHITECT = ?, and now a list of fourteen dates and times.

On Jeremy's desk, in a clear evidence bag, the black flip phone. It's plugged into a charging cable that runs out of a slit in the bag. The screen glows faintly.

Jeremy types a warrant affidavit with two fingers. Rosa paces.

ROSA
Two days.

JEREMY
Maybe tomorrow if Okoye's in a good mood.

ROSA

Okoye has never been in a good mood.
Okoye was born in a bad mood and has
maintained it professionally for sixty
years.

JEREMY

Then two days.

Rosa stops pacing. She looks at the phone glowing in its
bag.

ROSA

It's charged.

JEREMY

(not looking up)

No.

ROSA

I didn't say anything.

JEREMY

You were thinking about it very
loudly.

ROSA

It's one call. The number's in the
phone. The phone's in evidence. He's
not going to complain.

JEREMY

We don't know who's on the other end.
If we call it, we tell them we have
the phone.

ROSA

Or we find out if it's even on.

JEREMY

We wait for the warrant.

ROSA

And in two days, whoever strangled
T-Bone Gaines with his bare hands buys
a new phone and a plane ticket.

Jeremy stops typing. He looks at the phone. He looks at his partner.

JEREMY

Delgado.

ROSA

Jackson.

JEREMY

If you touch that phone, I have to write it up.

ROSA

Then write it up.

She pulls on a latex glove. Reaches into the evidence bag. Opens the flip phone. Scrolls to the only contact.

ARCHITECT.

She presses CALL. Puts it on speaker.

A pause. A click.

Then, somewhere on a cell network, it begins to RING.

Jeremy stands up so fast his chair rolls into the wall.

CUT TO:

**23. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - LYRIC'S ROOM - NIGHT
(9:00 PM)**

Lyric in bed, face washed, bonnet on, a script on her lap she isn't reading. Marc sits in the armchair beside the bed, still in his dinner clothes, napkin finally out of his collar.

LYRIC

Uncle Marc. Can I ask you something hypothetical?

MARC-ANTHONY

My favorite kind of question.

LYRIC

Hypothetically. If a person really,
really wanted something. Like, knew in
their whole body it was the thing they
were supposed to do. But somebody who
loved them said no.

MARC-ANTHONY

(careful)

Hypothetically.

LYRIC

Totally hypothetically.

MARC-ANTHONY

Is this person a thirteen-year-old in
a Westbrook blazer who wears her
blazer inside out?

LYRIC

(too fast)

I don't know anybody like that.

MARC-ANTHONY

(smiling)

Okay.

(beat)

Hypothetically. I'd tell that person
that wanting something isn't a crime.
It's the best thing about being alive.

LYRIC

But?

MARC-ANTHONY

But the person who said no loves them
too. And they might have a reason the
person can't see yet.

LYRIC

What if the reason's dumb?

MARC-ANTHONY

Sometimes it is. Grown-ups have a lot
of dumb reasons. I've got a few.

LYRIC

Like what?

MARC-ANTHONY

I won't eat peach cobbler anymore.

LYRIC

Why?

MARC-ANTHONY

(beat)

Because it reminds me of somebody.

Lyric looks at him. She's smart enough to know she's just been told something real, and young enough not to know what it was.

LYRIC

Is that a sad reason?

MARC-ANTHONY

(standing, kissing her
forehead)

It's a grown-up reason. Go to sleep,
Chef.

LYRIC

(sleepy, sliding down under
the covers)

You're going to let them audition,
right? Hypothetically.

MARC-ANTHONY

(at the door)

Hypothetically, everybody gets a shot.

(beat)

Actually, not hypothetically.
Actually.

He turns off the light.

CUT TO:

24. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY - NIGHT (9:41 PM)

Dark, except for one desk lamp. Marc, back from dinner, sits reading the Crowns script. The house is quiet. Lyric is asleep upstairs.

A sound.

A low, insistent BUZZ from inside the desk. From the locked top drawer.

Marc goes very still.

He sets down the fountain pen. He takes a small key from his pocket and unlocks the drawer.

Inside: a plain black phone. No case. No brand. A phone that almost never rings, because almost nobody in the world has the number.

It's ringing now. The screen glows.

The caller ID reads: T-BONE.

Marc stares at it. A dead man is calling him.

The phone buzzes in his hand. Once. Twice. Three times.

Marc doesn't answer. He doesn't move. He watches the name on the screen the way a man watches a snake.

The buzzing stops. The screen goes dark.

CUT TO:

25. INT. APD HEADQUARTERS - HOMICIDE SQUAD ROOM - CONTINUOUS (9:41 PM)

The call rings out. The flip phone's screen: CALL ENDED. 0:00.

Rosa lowers it slowly. Jeremy stands across from her, furious and silent.

ROSA

It's on.

JEREMY

(quiet, controlled)

You just told whoever that is that we have his phone.

ROSA

I just found out it's alive. That's more than we knew an hour ago.

JEREMY

You made them nervous.

ROSA

Good. Nervous people make mistakes.

JEREMY

(beat)

Nervous people run.

He takes the phone out of her gloved hand, drops it back into the evidence bag, and seals it.

JEREMY (CONT'D)

And now I have to write it up.

He sits back down at his desk and starts typing, harder than before. Rosa looks at the whiteboard. ARCHITECT = ?

ROSA

(softly)

Whoever you are. You just saw his name come up on your phone.

(beat)

I hope it scared you.

CUT TO:

26. INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S ESTATE - STUDY - CONTINUOUS (9:43 PM)

Marc still holds the black phone. He hasn't moved.

He turns it over. He takes out the battery with steady fingers. Sets the battery on one side of the desk and the phone on the other.

Then he picks up his regular phone and dials. It rings once.

KANE (V.O.)
(filtered)
Yeah.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very calm)
Kane. Somebody just called me.

KANE (V.O.)
Who?

MARC-ANTHONY
(beat)
T-Bone.

Silence on the line.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
From a phone I never gave him. On a
number he should never have had.

(beat)
Wake up Zeke. Wake up everybody.

He hangs up. He sits alone in the lamplight, looking at
the two halves of the black phone lying on his desk.

His face is perfectly calm. His eyes are not.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(whisper)
Who gave you my number, T?

HOLD on Marc in the dark.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE #0002